Tamil Nadu
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Tamil Nadu's Jain Spiritual Trail

Jainism once flourished across Tamil Nadu, and exploring the Jain sites in the state can offer a truly mesmerizing experience.

Jainism has deep roots in Tamil Nadu, where it flourished in ancient times under royal patronage. Numerous caves, frescoes, stone beds, inscriptions and sculptures attest to this. Today, Jain sites spread across the State serve as a gentle reminder of that time.

A seven-hour drive from Chennai will bring you to one of the most prominent Jain sites—the Pallava-era Chithannavasal or Sittanavasal Cave. Also known as Arivar Koil, this rock-cut cave temple in Pudukottai District has exquisite frescoes on the ceiling that will fill you with awe. Two notable ones depict a royal couple and a lotus tank with marine creatures. If you're travelling with children, there's a children's park, dancing fountain and boating jetties at hand to keep them entertained. The entrance fees for the cave temple and Jain Bed are Rs 20 (Indian) and Rs 250 (Foreigner). Don't miss the miniature statue park.

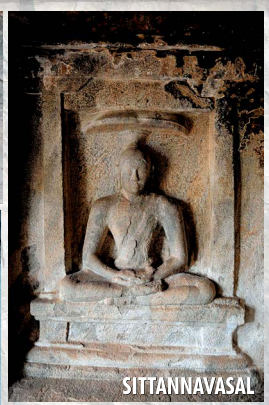
On the same day, a two-hour drive from Chithannavasal will take you to the village of Arittapatti, a glorious repository of Jain treasures in the Melur block of Madurai District. The highlight is the 8th-century Samanar Hills Cave Temple, with its exquisite sculptures and carvings of the Jain Tirthankaras. Another must-visit is the Panchapandavar Cave which, apart from its profusion of Jain sculptures, also has inscriptions in the Tamil and Brahmi scripts. Do trek up to the nearby Kalinjamalai hillock for breathtaking views of the surrounding countryside. Tamil Nadu's first biodiversity site has been set up at Arittapatti, so along with exploring Jain heritage you can indulge in a spot of birdwatching.

Next day head to Anaimalai, which is considered a sacred place by the Tamil Jains and lies a 30-min drive away. Ladan Koil here is a rock-cut temple dedicated to Lord Muruga. It also contains sculptures of Jain saints. Jain bas-relief sculptures of Mahavira and Gomateshwara can be found at the top of the hill.

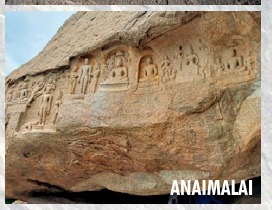
After lunch, another half-hour drive in the return direction will get you to Kidaripatti village, where you must stop to see the Alagarmalai cavern for its Brahmi inscriptions and beds carved out of rock. This was once home to Jain monks and a massive rock just below the cave has a beautiful carved image of a Jain Tirthankara.

The next morning drive 2.5 hours to the Kalugumalai hillock in Thoothukudi District which houses the 8th-century Kalugumalai Jain Beds. Images of several Jain Tirthankaras like Gomateshwara and Parsvanatha are carved in niches in the beds and are fine examples of Pandyan art. While here do visit the spectacular Vettuvan Koil dedicated to Lord Shiva. You can stay the night in Thiruchendur, 2.5 hours away, as it will make the next day's travel easier.









An all-day drive the next day will get you to Tiruvannamalai. On the way, you can explore the Thirunarukondai Jain Temple in Singavaram village near Gingee. This site is extremely special because, next to the two Jain caves here, there is a massive boulder with sculptures of all 24 Jain Tirthankaras in one place—a rare occurrence.

Vallimalai in Vellore District is a comfortable 2.5-hour drive from here. It was a prominent Jain centre in the 8th-9th century. The Vallimalai Jain caves have several carvings and inscriptions across three chambers. There is an exquisite torana as well.

Under two hours' drive from here, the Thirupparuthikundram Jain Temple, also known as Trilokyanathar Temple, in Kancheepuram dates from the 8th century. While the temple is dedicated to Jain Tirthankaras, it is noteworthy for integrating Hindu deities with Jain ones. You will be able to return to Chennai on the same day.

Tamil Nadu's trail of Jain monuments is a spiritually uplifting journey that will leave you suffused with tranquillity. It's an excellent—and convenient—way to explore the state's Jain heritage.

